STEPPA

Your Neighbourhood. On the Move.

HACKATHON PROJECT PROPOSAL

Team discussion draft | 19 October 2026

1. Executive Summary

Steppa is a proposed neighbourhood-based delivery and errand-running platform that connects people who need everyday tasks completed with nearby runners who can complete them. It aims to make local errands more convenient, create flexible earning opportunities, and help small businesses reach customers who need delivery.

For the hackathon, the goal is not to build every feature of a full commercial service. The team would develop a focused, demonstrable minimum viable product (MVP) that shows how a customer creates a request, a runner accepts it, and both parties follow the task through to completion with clear pricing and status updates.

2. The Problem

In many neighbourhoods, students, households, busy workers, older residents, and small businesses may need help with short-distance deliveries or everyday errands. Existing delivery options may not cover every local task, may be too costly for some requests, or may not be designed for informal and community-based businesses. At the same time, people who could perform local errands may lack a simple way to find legitimate paid tasks.

These are the problems Steppa proposes to investigate. The team should validate them with a few potential customers, runners, and local businesses before treating them as proven market facts.

3. Proposed Solution

Steppa would provide a simple digital workflow for requesting, accepting, tracking, and completing local errands. The initial pilot would focus on a defined neighbourhood or campus-adjacent area, rather than trying to operate everywhere at once.

- Customers submit a task with pickup and drop-off details, task description, and a displayed price or estimate.
- Runners view available requests, accept a task, and update its status.
- Customers can see progress through clear states such as Requested, Accepted, In Progress, and Completed.
- A proof-of-completion step, such as a confirmation code or delivery photo where appropriate, helps close the task.
- Small businesses can request delivery for customer orders.
- A basic support/reporting path lets users flag a problem or cancel according to clear rules.

4. Primary Users and Value

User group	Potential value
Customers	Convenient access to local errands and delivery without needing to find help informally.

Runners	A way to discover and complete local tasks for agreed earnings.
Small businesses	An additional way to offer local delivery and serve nearby customers.

5. Hackathon MVP Scope

Recommended features to build and demonstrate:

- Basic customer and runner sign-in or clearly separated demo accounts.
- Create an errand/delivery request with task details and locations.
- Runner task list and accept-task action.
- Order status updates visible to the customer.
- Transparent fee/earnings breakdown in the demo.
- Completion confirmation and a simple issue-reporting option.
- A lightweight dashboard showing active and completed requests.

Keep payments in a sandbox or simulated demo unless the team has approved access to a legitimate payment integration. Do not collect real card details or claim that a simulated transaction is a real payment.

6. Suggested Technical Approach

A practical prototype could use Flutter for a mobile-first interface, Supabase for authentication, PostgreSQL data, storage, and realtime updates, and Mapbox for map display if time permits. A sandbox payment flow or simulated wallet can demonstrate the concept without handling real funds. The team should confirm the stack based on member skills, hackathon rules, available accounts, and build time.

Possible core data entities: Users, RunnerProfiles, Requests, RequestStatusHistory, BusinessProfiles, PriceBreakdowns, and Reports. Access controls should ensure users can only view or change records they are authorised to access.

7. Safety, Trust, and Responsible Design

- Use minimal personal information and do not expose phone numbers or exact addresses unnecessarily.
- Restrict access to task details to the relevant customer, assigned runner, and authorised support role.
- Show pricing and any service fee before a customer confirms a request.
- Define cancellation, refunds, damaged/missing-item handling, and dispute escalation—even if handled manually in the prototype.
- For groceries or purchases requiring the runner to pay upfront, avoid making the runner carry unbounded financial risk. The MVP can exclude these tasks or use a clearly capped, pre-agreed process.
- Do not claim that background checks, identity verification, insurance, or payment protection exist unless implemented and verified.

8. Business Model and Sustainability

Potential revenue options for later validation include a transparent service fee per completed task, a delivery fee paid by the customer or business, and business-focused packages for frequent deliveries. The team should test whether the price remains affordable while fairly compensating runners and covering support and operating costs. No pricing model should be presented as validated until tested with users.

9. Fit With the Hackathons

FNB App of the Year Hackathon

Potential alignment: Youth entrepreneurship and small-business growth, because Steppa could help local businesses offer delivery and create earning opportunities for young runners. The pitch should connect this benefit directly to the challenge, show a working app and user journey, and address security, sustainability, and measurable impact. The team should confirm that the final framing meets the organisers' challenge requirements.

MTN Group Technology Hackathon

Steppa could be adapted to a problem involving digital commerce, customer experience, cloud-enabled coordination, or secure digital transactions. However, the team must first agree on a specific problem and check the organisers' rules and expectations. The Team-088-MongoDB name alone should not be treated as proof that MongoDB is mandatory; verify this with the organisers or team instructions.

10. How We Could Measure Impact

- Number of requests created and completed during a pilot.
- Average time from request to runner acceptance.
- Completion and cancellation rates.
- Customer and runner satisfaction from short feedback surveys.
- Number of local businesses trialling the service.
- Runner earnings per completed task, reported transparently.

11. Proposed Build Plan

Stage	Focus	Deliverable
1. Align	Agree on primary user and problem; check hackathon criteria.	One-sentence problem statement and success metric.
2. Design	Map customer and runner journeys; sketch core screens.	Wireframes and agreed MVP scope.
3. Build	Implement request creation, task acceptance, and status updates.	Working end-to-end prototype.
4. Validate	Test with a few people; fix confusing or broken flows.	Feedback notes and improved demo.
5. Pitch	Prepare architecture, security, business model, impact, and demo.	Short pitch and presentation materials.

12. Key Risks and Mitigations

Risk	Mitigation
Too many features for the time available	Limit the MVP to one complete customer-to-runner workflow.
Insufficient trust between users	Use task status visibility, completion confirmation, and a reporting path.
Runner must pay upfront for an order	Exclude or cap these tasks in the MVP; require a

	clear pre-agreed process.
Payment integration delays	Use sandbox mode or a clearly labelled simulation.
Unproven demand or pricing	Interview potential users and label assumptions honestly.
Location/privacy exposure	Restrict access to task details and collect only necessary data.

13. Decisions Needed From the Team

- Which challenge are we solving first: youth earning opportunities, local business delivery, or customer convenience?
- Which hackathon is this proposal for, and what are its exact rules and submission requirements?
- Who is the primary user and where would we pilot first?
- Which features can the team realistically complete in the available time?
- Which stack best matches the team's skills and required platform?
- How will we validate the problem and measure success?

Proposed Pitch

"Steppa connects neighbourhoods to the people who can help them move. We are building a simple platform where customers can request local errands, runners can find paid tasks, and small businesses can offer delivery to nearby customers. Our hackathon MVP will demonstrate the full journey from request to completion, with transparent pricing, status updates, and basic safety controls. We will start with a focused local pilot, test the need with real users, and use the results to decide how Steppa can grow sustainably."

This is a proposal for team discussion, not a claim that demand, pricing, or operational arrangements have already been validated. The team should agree on the target challenge, validate assumptions, and adapt the proposal to the selected hackathon before submission.